THE VIRAL LIST

- **Chandipura:** Causes swelling of brain. Symptoms include fever and bodyache. Outbreak reported from Gujarat
- **Nipah:** Causes respiratory issues, fever, coughing, sore throat and swelling of brain. Outbreak seen in Kerala
- **Zika:** May cause serious health complications in pregnant women. Symptoms include fever and bodyache. Outbreak reported in Maharashtra and Karnataka
- **Swine flu:** Causes moderate to severe respiratory symptoms, fever and sore throat. Outbreak recorded in Mumbai and Rajasthan
- **Avian flu:** May cause swelling of brain and pneumonia. Incidence reported in West Bengal
- **Dengue:** Causes high fever and drop in blood platelets. Outbreak seen in Maharashtra, Karnataka and Kerala
- **Chikungunya:** Causes high fever and intense muscle pain. Outbreak reported in Maharashtra

distancing, says Dr Yogesh Gupta, a consultant of internal medicine at Sterling Hospital, Ahmedabad.

Meanwhile, Maharashtra reported over 50 cases of infections by the Zika virus last month, prompting the Union ministry of health and family welfare to issue a health advisory to states to initiate measures to check the breeding of mosquitos and spread of mosquito-borne diseases. Like malaria, dengue and chikungunya, Zika is spread by the bite of infected mosquitoes. Maharashtra also saw an 83 per cent rise in cases of dengue between January and July, as compared to those reported during the same period last year. The Karnataka health department, too, has reported 19,313 dengue cases in the state between January and August 3. The number during the same period last year had been only 4,864.

To check the spread of mosquito-borne viruses, experts say, municipalities must clear stagnant water during monsoons, spray insecticides and improve sanitation to prevent breeding. In the past few years, Delhi had been among the states that had by its stringent efforts to check the breeding of mosquitos managed to bring down cases of dengue. But authorities in the national capital seem to be slipping up on the drive this year—as of July 6, Delhi has recorded over 256 dengue cases this year, nearly double the 136 cases recorded in the corresponding period last year and the highest since 2020, going by health department records. While most of the current outbreaks across states are being reported from isolated pockets, experts fear inaction or delayed action may result in more infections, especially as India is set to see another month or two of rain, what with aberrant monsoon patterns. ■

By Avishek G. Dastidar

"Are loco pilots not humans?" the Congress had asked on social media platforms, after Rahul Gandhi, leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, visited a running room, or rest room, for locomotive pilots at the New Delhi railway station last month to review their working conditions. Rahul himself spoke of their "16-hour" workday and "boiling hot" cabins. On August 1, during a budget discussion in Parliament, railways minister Ashwini Vaishnaw hit back with some numbers: 558 running rooms across the country have been air-conditioned, said the minister, as have 7,000 train engine cabs.

Unfortunately, neither the minister, nor the Opposition, went beyond the general working conditions of loco pilots to talk about the specific grievances that women on the job claim they have been raising for years—the absence of basic facilities like toilets on locomotives and separate spaces, including changing rooms and washrooms for women, in running rooms. "We often have to use the public toilets at stations even to change," says a woman loco pilot, who has been working for 18 years and is currently posted in Rajasthan.

A 26-year-old woman assistant loco pilot told INDIA TODAY she doesn't drink water for hours while on duty and wears an adult diaper. The strain is enough to make her regret accepting this "well-paying government job", she says. Based in Delhi, the assistant loco pilot earns

WORKPLACE WOES

IN AUGUST 2013, a high-powered committee under retired secretary to Government of India, D.P. Tripathi, submitted a report on improvements of the working conditions and duty hours of the drivers. The report quoted a psychological study by Railways the findings of which highlighted significantly more job-induced stress among loco pilots as compared to those in stationary roles